STIVEN CATALYST

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MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.



ROLE

THE ETHICAL LEADER

A good person is not yet an ethical leader, how ethics flows from the top to the front line, four reputations, the overlap with transformational leadership, the ten questions of the scale, and a card for one decision.

904 employees in 195 departments: the ethics of top management reached them through their own supervisors.

MAYER ET AL., 2009

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NO. 78 · ROLE

In this issue

Most managers think of themselves as decent people. The research on ethical leadership asks a harder question: does the team know it, and does the way the team is led show it? A reputation for ethics is built in front of others, or not at all.

Linda Treviño and colleagues found two pillars behind that reputation: the moral person and the moral manager. Crossed, they give four reputations, and only one is ethical leadership. In 195 departments the ethics of top management reached employees through their supervisors. Ethical leadership overlaps strongly with transformational leadership, yet still predicts behaviour beyond it. The ten-item scale shows what employees look at.

Stiven Janaqi EDITOR · STIVEN CATALYST

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HOW TO READ THIS ISSUE

Figure
Every figure has its source and year at the foot of its page.

Our reading
Where the editor interprets rather than the research, it says so.

Practice
The steps and the card are proposals to try, not research results.

COVER STORY

A good person is not enough

Linda Treviño, Laura Hartman and Michael Brown interviewed senior executives and corporate ethics officers about what makes an executive known as an ethical leader (2000). The answer was a reputation that rests on two pillars.

Moral person	Moral manager
Traits: honesty, integrity, trustworthiness	Role modelling, in view of others
Behaviours others can see	Rewards and discipline
How decisions are made	Communicating about ethics and values

The first pillar is about who you are, the second about what you make of the team. A leader can be honest in private and still leave employees unsure what is expected of them, because ethics is never part of how the work is led.

OUR READING

The team cannot see your conscience. It sees what you reward, what you correct and what you talk about.

Source: Linda K. Treviño, Laura P. Hartman & Michael Brown, California Management Review 42(4), 2000

The pillars and traits as in the article's Figure 1; 40 interviews, 20 with senior executives and 20 with ethics officers.

THE NUMBERS

How low it flows

David Mayer and colleagues asked whether ethical leadership at the top reaches the people who do the work, or stops at the level below (2009).

904
employees surveyed

195
managers, in 195 departments

THE TRICKLE-DOWN THE STUDY TESTED

01	02	03
Top management	**Supervisor**	**The group**
its ethical leadership	their ethical leadership	less deviance, more helping

Ethical leadership at both levels went with less deviance in the group, such as taking things or coming in late, and with more voluntary help. The effect of the top ran through the supervisors.

OUR READING

The front line reads the company's values from the person it reports to.

Source: David M. Mayer, Maribeth Kuenzi, Rebecca Greenbaum et al., Organizational Behavior and Human Decision Processes 108(1), 2009

Survey data at the level of groups: links, not causes. The examples are from the study's scale; 891 of the 904 were analysed.

THE MODEL

Four reputations

Treviño and her co-authors set the ethical leader against three alternatives: the unethical leader, the hypocritical leader, who talks the ethics talk but does not walk the ethics walk, and the ethically neutral leader.

MORAL MANAGER

Hypocritical
Speaks of values that their own conduct does not follow.
STRONG MANAGER · WEAK PERSON

Ethical
Lives the values and makes them part of how the team is led.
STRONG MANAGER · STRONG PERSON

Unethical
Seen to act wrongly, and leaves ethics out of the team.
WEAK MANAGER · WEAK PERSON

Ethically neutral
May be decent, but ethics is not on the agenda, so employees cannot tell.
WEAK MANAGER · PERSON UNCLEAR

MORAL PERSON

OUR READING

Silence soon stops being neutral. Where nobody talks about how results are reached, the number is heard as the only rule.

Source: Linda K. Treviño, Laura P. Hartman & Michael Brown, California Management Review 42(4), 2000

The matrix follows the article's Figure 2; the short texts in the cells are the editors'.

More in the essay Leading people without losing the person

WHAT THE RESEARCH SAYS

Ethical, or simply a good leader?

Julia Hoch and colleagues pooled the studies on the newer leadership styles and asked how far each overlaps with transformational leadership, the style that inspires and sets an example (2018).

CORRELATION WITH TRANSFORMATIONAL LEADERSHIP, CORRECTED ρ



For most outcomes ethical leadership added little beyond transformational leadership. Thomas Ng and Daniel Feldman (101 samples, 29,620 people, 2015) found it still predicted performance, helping and counterproductive behaviour, if weakly in some cases; trust in the leader carried the link to attitudes and performance.

OUR READING

Inspiring and ethical are two different things, though the surveys mostly find them in the same leaders.

Sources: Julia E. Hoch, William H. Bommer, James H. Dulebohn et al., Journal of Management 44(2), 2018 (via Abstract; ρ from later reviews); Thomas W. H. Ng & Daniel C. Feldman, Journal of Applied Psychology 100(3), 2015 (via Abstract); Akanksha Bedi, Can M. Alpaslan & Sandy Green, Journal of Business Ethics 139(3), 2016 (via Abstract)

The scale runs from 0 to 1; ρ from Hoch et al. as later reviews report them. Bedi et al. (2016) link it with fair treatment by the leader (see No. 70); links were stronger in the public sector.

HOW IT IS MEASURED

Ten questions for the team

Michael Brown, Linda Treviño and David Harrison define ethical leadership as acting rightly oneself and promoting it in others through two-way communication, reinforcement and decisions (2005). Over seven studies they built a ten-item scale that employees fill in about their supervisor.

How they act	What they promote
lives ethically in private too	talks about ethics and values
can be trusted	sets an example of the right way
decides fairly, in balance	judges success also by how it was reached
has employees' interests in mind	asks: what is the right thing to do?
listens to employees	disciplines breaches of ethics

The ten items formed a single factor. In the original studies the scale predicted job satisfaction, dedication and willingness to report problems to management.

OUR READING

A boss can score well in the first column and stay silent in the second. That is the neutral leader of page 5.

Source: Michael E. Brown, Linda K. Treviño & David A. Harrison, Organizational Behavior and Human Decision Processes 97(2), 2005

Items shortened and translated by us, from Table 3 of the article; the two columns follow the two parts of the definition and are the editors' sorting.

TOOL OF THE ISSUE

The right-way card

One card per decision that tests the standard: a target under pressure, a shortcut, a complaint. Before pushing harder on a number, check how it is being reached.

01 The decision what it is, and who it affects

02 The right thing to do the question asked aloud, and the answer

03 How the result is reached what would make the wrong way faster

04 Who was heard the people who do the work, before deciding

05 What the team was told the standard and the reason, in one sentence

06 What was rewarded or corrected and whether the same would hold for anyone

Sources: Linda K. Treviño, Laura P. Hartman & Michael Brown, California Management Review 42(4), 2000; Michael E. Brown, Linda K. Treviño & David A. Harrison, Organizational Behavior and Human Decision Processes 97(2), 2005

Proposed by the editors, drawing on the moral manager pillar of Treviño et al. (2000) and the items of the scale by Brown et al. (2005).

Open the tool: KPI Diagnostic stivencatalyst.com/tools/kpi-diagnostic/

SOURCES AND METHOD

Every figure has a source.

The figures in this issue come from the sources below. The year shows how recent each one is.

Moral Person and Moral Manager: How Executives Develop a Reputation for Ethical Leadership
Linda K. Treviño, Laura P. Hartman & Michael Brown, California Management Review 42(4), 2000
https://doi.org/10.2307/41166057

How Low Does Ethical Leadership Flow? Test of a Trickle-Down Model
David M. Mayer, Maribeth Kuenzi, Rebecca Greenbaum et al., Organizational Behavior and Human Decision Processes 108(1), 2009
https://doi.org/10.1016/j.obhdp.2008.04.002

Do Ethical, Authentic, and Servant Leadership Explain Variance Above and Beyond Transformational Leadership? A Meta-Analysis
Julia E. Hoch, William H. Bommer, James H. Dulebohn et al., Journal of Management 44(2), 2018 · via Abstract; ρ from later reviews
https://doi.org/10.1177/0149206316665461

Ethical Leadership: Meta-Analytic Evidence of Criterion-Related and Incremental Validity
Thomas W. H. Ng & Daniel C. Feldman, Journal of Applied Psychology 100(3), 2015 · via Abstract
https://doi.org/10.1037/a0038246

A Meta-analytic Review of Ethical Leadership Outcomes and Moderators
Akanksha Bedi, Can M. Alpaslan & Sandy Green, Journal of Business Ethics 139(3), 2016 · via Abstract
https://doi.org/10.1007/s10551-015-2625-1

Ethical Leadership: A Social Learning Perspective for Construct Development and Testing
Michael E. Brown, Linda K. Treviño & David A. Harrison, Organizational Behavior and Human Decision Processes 97(2), 2005
https://doi.org/10.1016/j.obhdp.2005.03.002

EDITORIAL METHOD

Each figure was checked for its year, its publisher and what it measures, in the full text where it could be opened. A source read only in a summary, an abstract or excerpts is marked “via”. A figure not confirmed in what was read is marked so on its page, or left out. The editor's interpretation is marked “Our reading”.



MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.

Every issue, one management question, checked against the best research.

ALL ISSUES

stivencatalyst.com/magazine/management-review.html

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Edited by Stiven Janaqi, who answers for it; “the editors” in this publication means him. Its texts, translations, layout and the checking of figures against their sources are done in working sessions with Claude, an AI model by Anthropic.
stivencatalyst.com/how-this-is-made.html